THE LONG-ESTABLISHED TRADITION of naval warfare fought between ships armed with guns was rendered increasingly obsolete in the 20th century by a series of technological innovations. Fleets found a new focus in the form of the aircraft carrier, which replaced the battleship as the capital ship. The introduction of missiles made guns largely redundant and missile-armed submarines became a crucial element in the awesomely destructive nuclear forces of the major powers. The successive transformations of naval warfare in the course of the century brought sea battles to an unprecedented climax in World War II—viewed as a whole, by far the greatest naval conflict in history—then appeared more or less to have abolished them, at least as large-scale engagements between opposing naval forces.



LIMITATION AND EXPANSION

After World War I, defeated Germany was temporarily banned from possessing a navy by the terms of the Versailles Treaty. In an attempt to avoid an expensive arms race between the remaining naval powers, an international agreement on fleet sizes was negotiated at the Washington Conference in 1922. Britain and the United States were accorded parity, with a fleet tonnage of 535,000 tons each, Japan was allowed 315,000 tons, and France and Italy 175,000 tons each. The British Royal Navy's acceptance of equality with America was a stark acknowledgement of Britain's waning power.

Nothing of this worthy attempt at arms limitation survived the rise of aggressive nationalist regimes in Japan, Germany, and Italy in the 1930s. The Japanese became increasingly restive at their restriction to third place in the pecking order and, after trying in vain to overturn this at the London Conference of 1930,

Amphibious landing
US troops disembark from a landing ship onto the Normandy beaches in June 1944. Amphibious operations, often conducted on a vast scale, made a crucial contribution to the Allied victory in WWII.





